

INSECT APPEAL

A court convicts two Czech nationals, but will it deter a global insect trade eyeing India's rich biodiversity?

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Call it a beauty pageant with a difference. A small gathering of tribal youths queue up outside a nondescript hotel in a small town in Visakhapatnam district of Andhra Pradesh holding plastic bags and ventilated clear plastic jars. What they're selling are huge, velvet-coated palm-sized tarantula spiders, stunningly beautiful, but with a bite that can kill a human. The youths tell a shaky hand-held camera exactly what they are doing there: trying to sell the spiders to a German tourist camping in the hotel. Each spider will fetch them between Rs 500 and Rs 5,000. A tidy sum for an eight-legged creature that remains relegated to the obscure in India.

Wildlife officials aren't surprised by this footage, shot by a local television reporter last December. For years, foreign nationals have been descending on Indian forests and spiriting away insects. Two months ago, two Czech nationals were arrested for stealing insects near Darjeeling's Singalila National Park. The duo—Prague-based entomologist Petr Svecha and insect trader Emil Kucera—was recently convicted by a local court.

India is one of the world's 12 mega-diverse countries as it harbours a significant chunk of the earth's species. This includes 45,000 plant species, 89,000 animal species, and a staggering four lakh insect species, with several still waiting to be discovered. "Insects are the unknown frontier," shrugs Traffic India Chief Samir Sinha. Raiding this frontier, like the latter day Indiana Joneses, are dozens of eco-pi-

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